

Inside Europe's deadlocked budget talks

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur.

In today's Playbook:

- The EU's biggest political family is split over how to deal with the far right.
- Does Europe need to behave more like NATO? Defense ministers tackle new proposals.
- Faces in the crowd: Friedrich Merz, Emmanuel Macron, Siegfried Murešan, Pedro López de Pablo, Sirpa Pietikäinen, Manfred Weber, Kaja Kallas, Maggie O'Farrell, Hendrik Wüst and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick ask whether Europe needs its own Article 4 as Russia keeps testing how far it can push NATO.

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DRIVING THE DAY

LEAKED CABLE — NO ONE IS BUDGING ON THE BUDGET: EU capitals are hopelessly deadlocked over the bloc's next long-term budget and the prospect of a deal this year is fading, according to a leaked German diplomatic cable seen by POLITICO.

"No potential areas for compromise were apparent" during a recent meeting of Europe ministers, said the Sept. 22 cable obtained by POLITICO's Jasper Bennink in Berlin.

Reality check: The blunt assessment of the German diplomat who observed the meeting reveals a lack of tangible progress despite months of talks between ministers and diplomats on the Multiannual Financial Framework (MFF). And it ramps up pressure on EU leaders to start moving their red lines when they gather on Oct. 15 — or admit there will be no deal this year.

The “entrenched positions” show bilateral talks have revealed “no surprises,” the cable states — and that’s prompting Ireland, which holds the EU’s rotating presidency, to plead with envoys to start compromising.

Germany’s view: The cable suggests Berlin’s cost-cutting faction holds the upper hand, arguing that the MFF’s “financial leeway” would be determined by “net contributors,” or wealthier EU states.

Pity Dublin: Ireland is working to a deadline, due to produce its next negotiating document, or “negobox,” that will act as a basis for talks between leaders by early October. It’s a “delicate balancing act” on Ireland’s behalf, the cable’s author writes. (A spokesperson for Germany’s embassy to the EU declined to comment, saying Berlin never comments on “alleged leaks.”)

Step back: It’s no secret that MFF talks are deadlocked, but the cable shows it’s entirely up to leaders to solve the problem — a tall order considering German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and French President Emmanuel Macron have both been weakened politically. That makes concessions on either side less likely, despite the fact that a Paris-Berlin precursor deal is necessary for any agreement, per one senior national official who was granted anonymity to discuss the talks.

Et tu, Manu? Merz and Macron announced in July they would work closely together in the negotiations. But while Germany, the Netherlands, Austria, Denmark, Finland, Sweden and Belgium “emphasized the need for significant cuts,” France was merely “open to targeted cuts,” according to the report. France was also among the countries that said that “cuts in the areas of agriculture and cohesion are out of the question.”

Can new EU taxes save it? A founder of the Irish betting giant Paddy Power is suggesting an EU-wide gambling tax could be a way out of the deadlock — and he’s all in favor. Stewart Kenny told Playbook’s Gregorio Sorgi that if bookmakers “have to pay for the harm some of their products are causing … well, that is a very healthy thing.”

It’s up to Ireland to decide whether such a tax, which some estimates say could generate up to €5 billion a year, gets onto a shortlist of so-called own resources to be discussed by leaders in October. Malta — home to a big betting sector — and Italy are leading a push against the idea, per a senior EU official.

But Kenny, who says he has “huge regrets” that he didn’t do more to tackle gambling addiction while at Paddy Power, brushed off concerns that a tax could push gamblers into the illegal market. A tax is “part of the gig,” he said, noting that it could help curb online advertising and children’s exposure to gambling.

BIG AND BREAKING

PRESSURE POINT: Western allies are worried that Moscow could use the sprawling Arctic archipelago to test NATO militarily amid growing uncertainty over Washington’s commitment to European defense, Victor Jack reports .

SCOOP — THE EU’S GROWTH GAMBIT: Brussels is developing proposals that would give the four frontrunners for EU membership — Montenegro, Ukraine, Moldova and Albania — targeted “roadmaps” to bring them in sooner rather than later, my colleague Gabriel Gavin reveals . A landmark review will conclude that new rules can be put in place to stop new joiners backsliding without changing the bloc’s fundamental laws.

STOCKPILE SCRAMBLE: German companies are rushing to stockpile critical raw materials, alarmed by the risk that Beijing could restrict rare earth exports if next month’s trade talks between the EU and China break down, Frida Preuss and Carlo Martuscelli report .

RUSSIAN INFILTRATION: A U.S.-based data-extraction firm accused of being secretly run from Russia has worked on EU-backed projects and sold its services to European law enforcement agencies, according to documents seen by POLITICO .

TACKLING THE FAR RIGHT

THE EPP’S GREAT DILEMMA: The European People’s Party is already preparing its strategy to head off the far right at the 2029 EU election — but interviews and internal meeting records reveal deep internal splits over its approach, Max Grier reports .

Us against them: The next European Parliament election will pit “anti-European populists against the EPP parties,” EPP vice chair and Romanian PM nominee Siegfried Mureșan said. So the party needs to come up with an “attractive enough” program that can compete with the far right’s promises, EPP spokesperson Pedro López de Pablo said.

The choice ahead: National factions will need to bridge gaps over how to handle the far right — and decide whether to hold their ground or follow the populist parties on migration, climate, and gender and sexual rights to win back voters. “This is the political history, the historical dilemma EPP needs to decide … are we center-right or are we another right-wing party?” said Finnish EPP lawmaker Sirpa Pietikäinen.

Conversations will unofficially kick off today and tomorrow on the sidelines of the EPP’s political assembly in Toulouse. Formal work on the “Win2029” task force announced by Manfred Weber, which aims to shape the party’s policy program for the campaign in three years, will start in earnest at a retreat in Sicily in October and continue at the party congress in Rome in the spring.

More cuts: At the assembly, lawmakers are set to back a resolution calling for more simplification of EU rules, including “a rigorous application of the one-in, two-out principle, whereby every new obligation is quantified, including its full compliance cost, and matched by the removal of at least twice that burden elsewhere” in EU law, per a document seen by POLITICO.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The European Commission will publish recommendations today on how EU countries should monitor cardiovascular health as part of its Safe Hearts Plan. But what is that? It’s the EU’s first attempt to tackle the leading cause of mortality in Europe. The hope is to cut premature mortality caused by heart disease by 25% by 2035. The Commission wants everyone under 35 to receive at least one cardiovascular health check, with checks at least every five years for those between 35 and 64 and

more regular checks for those over 65.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

THE 'EMERGENCY PROTOCOL'

BE MORE LIKE NATO? EU defense ministers will today for the first time tackle the question of whether the bloc needs its own version of NATO's Article 4 — an "Emergency Security Protocol" — three EU diplomats and officials said.

Red alert: Emmanuel Macron and other EU leaders are sounding the alarm about the rising risks of a Russian attack, prompting European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen to pitch the emergency protocol during her State of the Union speech. The talks in today's Defense Council are likely to bring up the tension between the EU's plan and NATO, with some capitals arguing the military alliance has the bloc's defense needs well covered.

If there's a will: "If there is general agreement, then the EU can put quite a lot on the table" in terms of policy tools for hybrid attacks, including emergency response teams, and "pockets of money," said a senior EU official who was granted anonymity to discuss the expectations.

What else to watch: Chief EU diplomat Kaja Kallas is likely to press countries to hand over Patriot interceptor missiles to Ukraine while they wait for new deliveries from the U.S., the official said. Kallas is also leaning on governments to contribute more ships to the ASPIDES maritime security mission in the Middle East.

4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

TERROR PROBE: British counterterror police are investigating whether Iran was involved in an alleged plot to attack an RAF air base used by the U.S. during its war in the Middle East, Sky News reports . Donald Trump said the five suspects arrested yesterday were looking to do "big damage" to the base.

LATEST IN THE MIDDLE EAST: Iran said it will push again for a diplomatic solution to its conflict with the U.S. after Trump rejected Tehran's offer of a seven-day ceasefire in exchange for opening the Strait of Hormuz. Reuters has the write-up .

MUNICH MIGRATION MEETING: After migration ministers from 18 European countries gathered in Germany over the weekend, Commissioner Magnus Brunner told Playbook: "Illegal migration to the EU has dropped massively ... Now we need to implement our new common rules, and build further on them by strengthening Frontex, creating a new emergency response framework and expanding our migration diplomacy with third countries."

THE VOID AT THE HEART OF EUROPE'S CLIMATE RESPONSE: The EU has no shortage of climate crises to deal with — but there's no one in charge of coordinating its efforts, Zia Weise reports .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Occasional thundery showers. High of 22C.

GOT A SPARE €20? The European People's Party has now opened up membership to individual citizens for €20 a year, promising access to party congresses and events, regular briefings and "opportunities to engage directly with EPP leadership," according to an internal briefing seen by Max Grier. Any guesses on how many lobbyists will try to sign up?

GRÈVE MATTER: Teachers from Wallonia and Brussels are being urged to strike today after their September paychecks were unexpectedly lower than usual, despite assurances from the government that no pay changes are planned.

ANYTHING BUT BOHR-ING: Saint-Gilles' Bridge Theater will host the award-winning play "Copenhagen" from Oct. 15 to Nov. 6. Described as "a European story for Europe's capital," it pits physicists Werner Heisenberg and Niels Bohr against each other on the eve of WWII. Details [here](#) .

NOT HAPPENING TODAY: "Hamnet" author Maggie O'Farrell was due to speak at Bozar this evening but organizers say the event has been postponed "due to unforeseen circumstances." A new date has yet to be scheduled.

A FAREWELL TO TAT: The days of the area around Brussels' Grand-Place being a warren of cheap souvenir shops and oily frituurs could be coming to an end, with the city government planning new rules that would set a limit on certain types of businesses. BRUZZ has more .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: North Rhine-Westphalia premier Hendrik Wüst is visiting Turkey with a large business delegation and an even larger media entourage, as speculation grows that he could be the next German chancellor.

Paris: The National Rally and its allies won enough seats in yesterday's Senate election to form a parliamentary group in the upper house for the first time — a boost ahead of next year's presidential race.

London: Andy Burnham's top ministers will take the stage today at Labour's annual party conference in Liverpool.

Washington: Ohio Republican Senator Jon Husted is hoping a vote on curbing data-center power costs will help him blunt Democratic attacks in his reelection fight.

Ottawa: Donald Trump's trade war on Canada is a growing liability at home.

Canberra: The OpenAI hack has raised urgent questions about the state of Australia's cyber defenses .

**Our journalists will provide a live status check directly from the European Health Forum Gastein on key decisions and upcoming legislation in European health policy. Access a one-week trial of our Pro Morning Health Care Newsletter [here](#) . **

AGENDA

— Foreign Affairs Council (Defense) in Brussels. Doorstep with EU High Representative Kaja Kallas at 8 a.m. Press conference at 12:30 p.m. Watch live .

- Agriculture and Fisheries Council in Brussels, with Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen attending. Press conference around 5 p.m. Watch on delay . Hansen also meets Dutch Agriculture Minister Jaimi van Essen.
- French President Emmanuel Macron travels to Metz as part of Pope Leo XIV's apostolic visit and delivers a speech about Europe around 11 a.m.
- Informal meeting of EU energy ministers in Dublin.
- Health Commissioner Olivér Várhelyi holds a press conference on the Commission's recommendations on cardiovascular health and the launch of EU Screening Week at 1 p.m. Watch live .
- The European Parliament's Economic and Monetary Affairs Committee holds a monetary dialogue with European Central Bank President Christine Lagarde from 3:30 p.m. Watch live.
- Visegrád Group ministers meet in Štrbské Pleso, Slovakia. Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto attends.
- Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica meets Canadian Foreign Minister Anita Anand and attends the Second International Conference on Returning Ukrainian Children in Toronto, Canada.
- Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra meets Irish Deputy PM and Finance Minister Simon Harris and Climate, Environment, Energy and Transport Minister Darragh O'Brien.
- Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen is in the Netherlands, where she meets Foreign Minister Tom Berendsen, Economic Affairs Minister Heleen Herbert and Digital Economy Minister Willemijn Aerdts; and visits Eurojust and Europol. She'll deliver the Leiden University Europe Hub's 2026 distinguished lecture on "Europe's digital sovereignty" at 6 p.m. Details here .
- Union for the Mediterranean water ministers meet in Rome, with an address by Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall.
- Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin meets Lithuanian Finance Minister Taurimas Valys.
- EU Youth Conference in Dublin.

BIRTHDAYS

EU Ambassador to Morocco Dimitar Tzantchev; MEP Tineke Strik; journalist Hortense Goulard; FDA trade union National Officer Robert Eagleton; Métropole Européenne de Lille's Jeanne Duhem; Miloš Zeman, former president of the Czech Republic; Ana Brnabić, acting president of Serbia and speaker of the National Assembly of Serbia; author Simon Winchester.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Amazon:** Lucas Pinos' Novoma began with a simple ambition: to make well-being accessible to everyone. Founded in Toulouse, France, Novoma set out to create food supplements built on transparency, trust, and scientific rigor. As demand grew, Amazon helped Novoma reach customers across Europe." Amazon enabled us, as a small business, to reach new markets where we hadn't

existed before, and drive strong growth in just one year,” says Lucas. Novoma is one of thousands of European success stories selling on Amazon. In 2024, EU-based small businesses sold more than 1.3 billion products and generated over €34 billion in sales within the EU alone. Together, these entrepreneurs support an estimated 350,000 jobs across the EU, many in local and regional communities. By providing tools, logistics, and access to customers across borders, Amazon helps small businesses, like Novoma, grow beyond their local markets while staying rooted in their communities. Learn more about how Amazon helps European businesses thrive in our latest EU Small and Medium Enterprises Impact Report at [AboutAmazon.eu](https://aboutamazon.eu). **

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